

Some animals laugh, but not just like us

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Laughter is an important way for humans to connect, but recent studies show that other animals may also use laughter. Photo: John M Lund Photography Inc./Getty Images

Laughing comes so naturally to most people that they don't think about why they do it. Laughter is so important to humans that people can recognize it, even if they belong to a different culture or speak a different language. Humans use laughter as a way to connect and bond.

In April 2021, scientists published their work studying whether or not animals laugh. And maybe more importantly, if animals laugh while they play, which is something that happens just for fun. Play is something repeated, but it is not part of things like looking for food or shelter.

The work won't just help us understand animals better. It could help us understand how humans changed over time to laugh the way we do now.

Studying Animals That Laugh While Playing

Sasha Winkler is a graduate student at the University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA). She studies biological anthropology, which is the study of animal behavior. Winkler works with small monkeys called rhesus macaques. These monkeys would play together by chasing each other. One

day, Winkler noticed a sound the animals made during the play. The monkeys sounded like they were panting or out of breath. But it reminded Winkler of quiet laughter. This made Winkler wonder if other animals laugh while playing too.

Then, Winkler worked with Greg Bryant, a professor at UCLA. Winkler and Bryant read and reviewed research written by other scientists studying animals. They identified 65 different animals that laugh while playing. Most examples came from animals such as primates (monkeys and apes), rodents (rats) and mammals that live in the ocean (dolphins).

Winkler and Bryant found that many animals laugh so that their play partner knows they are having fun. This is important because animal play can sometimes look like fighting. Laughing is a way for animals to prevent play from becoming dangerous or harmful. Some animals also make a "play face," giving an expression like a smile to show that they are happy. But animal laughs are not quite the same as human laughs.

Animals' Different Laughing Sounds

When compared to human laughs, animal laughter can sound very different, especially between different animals. When vervet monkeys play, they make a purring sound. Rats make a very high-pitched trill sound. Bottlenose dolphins whistle and squawk while they swim and jump together. The squirrel monkey makes a soft peeping sound when playing.

Two types of birds also made laughing sounds: the Australian magpie and the kea parrot. In fact, laughter is one way that kea parrots let others know it's time to play. When scientists played a recording of kea parrot laughter, other kea parrots in the area would start playing together.

Most animals that laugh and play are mammals like us. Animals like fish, frogs, snakes and lizards don't seem to laugh, and scientists don't know if these animals even play at all.

The Evolution Of Human Laughing

Primates, such as monkeys, apes and gorillas, pant, chuckle, grunt, cackle, squeal and smack their lips when playing. This might help explain where human laughter comes from.

Experts believe that humans started to laugh while playing for the same reason that some animals do. Humans may have started off panting like some monkeys do, but over time laughter became the sounds we use today.

One big difference between human laughs and animal laughs is that humans laugh much more loudly. Most sounds animals make during play are very quiet so they can only be heard by the animal they are playing with. But for humans, loud laughter is a sign that we're part of a group.

It's really fascinating that so many animals use sounds during play. And that those sounds are for reasons similar to why humans make sounds. According to Winkler, human laughter is unique enough to create studies about it in the future.